



Openote



BRAND & STYLE GUIDE · V0.1

Ink on an open page.

The design system that makes Openote look, feel, and speak as one product — calm, precise, quietly excellent.

Draft v0.1 · 22 July 2026

Colour · Type · Components · Voice

Five principles

Openote is a tool for thinking. The interface should feel like good stationery: never loud, never in the way. Five principles govern every decision.

- 1 **The page is the hero.** Everything that isn't the user's content is chrome, and chrome recedes.
- 2 **Calm over clutter.** The opposite of OneNote's ribbon. Progressive disclosure; white space is a feature.
- 3 **Interpret, don't interrupt.** Formatting appears where you make it — no modal preview panes.
- 4 **Native in spirit, consistent in soul.** Honor each platform while keeping one Openote character.
- 5 **Accessible by default.** Contrast, keyboard paths, reduced motion and legible type are requirements, not settings.

THE IDEA

Ink, on an open page

The brand concept is **ink** — the fountain-pen line, the mathematician's margin note, the hand-drawn diagram — set on an **open page**. It ties together handwriting, math, and the freeform canvas, and the one thing that defines Openote: openness. Two motifs recur — the **ink stroke** and the **open corner**.

PERSONALITY

The unpretentious craftsman

Competent, calm, a little opinionated about openness, generous with control. Not a hype startup, not a corporate suite — a well-made open-source tool by people who care, expressed with quiet confidence.

Tagline: "Your notes. Your format. Every platform."

COLOUR

A palette of ink & brass on paper

Built around two brand hues — **Ink** (deep indigo, primary) and **Brass** (warm amber, accent) — on warm-neutral "paper" grays. Chosen to be distinct from OneNote's magenta-purple while staying in the considered, ink-on-paper world. Every pairing is designed to meet **WCAG 2.1 AA**.

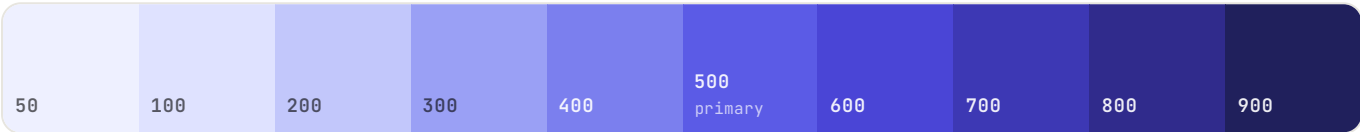
#5B5BE6

Ink 500 — primary

#EBB24A

Brass 400 — accent

Ink — the primary ramp



Brass — the accent (used sparingly)



Amber rarely meets 4.5:1 on white — use Brass 700 for accent *text*; reserve Brass 400 for fills, indicators and iconography.

Paper & Graphite (light)



Night ink (dark theme)



Semantic & content ink

Role	Light	Meaning
Success	#2E8B57	saved, synced, confirmations
Warning	#C67A12	reversible caution
Danger	#C63838	destructive actions, errors
Info	#2F6FB3	neutral information, tips

Default pen colours offered to users — legible on paper and night surfaces, colourblind-considerate:



Rule. Never rely on colour alone — pair every semantic colour with an icon and/or text.

Legible, open-licensed, quiet

display / 600 **Openote**

h1 / 600 **Think on an open page**

h2 / 600 **Your notes, your format**

body-lg / 400 The editor default — comfortable for reading and writing notes at length.

label / 500 Create notebook

caption / 400 Last edited 2 minutes ago · synced

mono / 400 $\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} 1/n^2 = \pi^2/6$

serif / opt. A reading-serif option for those who prefer a book-like note.

Inter

UI & body. Neutral, legible at small sizes. Open (OFL).

JetBrains Mono

Code. Distinguishable 0/O, 1/l/I. Open.

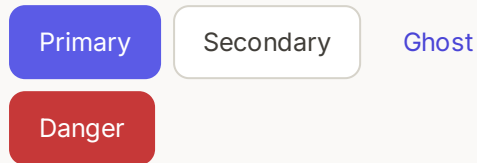
Source Serif · KaTeX/STIX

Reading-serif option; proper math glyph coverage.

Rules. One to two weights per view (400 + 600). Editor line length targets 60–80 characters in linear mode (the freeform canvas is exempt). Never justify body text; avoid all-caps except tiny tracked labels.

Quiet, consistent, considered

Buttons



One primary action per view. Visible focus ring (Ink 400, 2px, 2px offset). Clear hover / pressed / disabled states.

Tags & chips



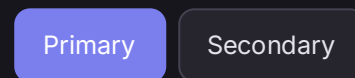
The built-in tag library uses distinct icons, not just colour. Rounded-full, subtle fill.

Elevation & shape

Borders and subtle tints over heavy shadows — flat and paper-like. Radii: `sm 4` · `md 8` · `lg 12` · `xl 16` · `full`. Canvas text boxes use `lg` with a near-invisible border until hovered.

Night ink

Not pure black — a deep warm charcoal so ink and brass glow without harshness. Interactive uses `Ink 400`; accent uses `Brass 400`.



CANVAS INTERACTION

The canvas is the product

- **Tools:** select/move, text (click empty space to create), pen · highlighter · eraser, lasso (later)
- **Pan:** space-drag / two-finger / scrollbars both axes.
Zoom: Ctrl-scroll / pinch, centred on cursor
- **Placement:** one-tap Free ↔ Snap-to-grid; hold a modifier to invert for one action; alignment guides in Ink 400
- **Parity:** every core action works with mouse, trackpad, touch *and* pen

ACCESSIBILITY

AA by default

- All text & UI meet WCAG 2.1 AA; meaning never encoded in colour alone
- Every action keyboard-reachable; visible focus ring everywhere; no traps
- Canvas blocks expose type + content to assistive tech (a first-class engineering task)
- Respect OS text-scaling & "reduce motion"; touch targets ≥ 44px

Voice & tone. Clear, warm, unpretentious — and precise about openness. Errors explain what happened and what to do next, calmly: *"Couldn't reach your sync server — your notes are safe on this device. Retry?"* We describe competitors accurately: OneNote's format isn't "completely closed," it's "documented but impractical to use elsewhere." Accuracy is part of the brand.

Do

Let the canvas breathe · one Ink primary per view · pair colour with icon/text · animate with purpose · write plainly · meet AA · keep tools contextual.

Don't

Rebuild the cluttered ribbon · make Brass dominant · rely on colour alone · add gratuitous shadows · use modals where inline undo works · overstate claims.